UNIT 23.2 · LEVEL B1

# Reported speech – tense changes (backshift)

50 questions · 6 parts

Date: _____ Score: _____ / 50

*When you finish, check the Answer Key at the end of this unit.*

## Part A · Multiple Choice (questions 1–10)

Circle the letter of the correct answer.

1 "I live in Rio," she said. → She said that she _____ in Rio.

**a)** has lived **b)** lives **c)** lived **d)** is living

2 "We are watching TV," they said. → They said they _____ TV.

**a)** were watching **b)** are watching **c)** watched **d)** have watched

3 "I bought a car," he said. → He said he _____ a car.

**a)** buys **b)** has bought **c)** was buying **d)** had bought

4 "I will call you," Tom said. → Tom said he _____ call me.

**a)** will **b)** would **c)** can **d)** did

5 "I can swim fast," she said. → She said she _____ swim fast.

**a)** can **b)** could **c)** would **d)** had

6 "I have finished my homework," Lucy said. → Lucy said she _____ her homework.

**a)** has finished **b)** was finishing **c)** will finish **d)** had finished

7 "I don't like coffee," he told me. → He told me he _____ coffee.

**a)** didn't like **b)** doesn't like **c)** won't like **d)** hadn't like

8 Last month she said, "I'm leaving tomorrow." → She said she was leaving _____.

**a)** tomorrow **b)** today **c)** the next day **d)** the day before

9 "I have been waiting for an hour," she said. → She said she _____ waiting for an hour.

**a)** has been **b)** will be **c)** is **d)** had been

10 Yesterday Mom said, "Sam is sleeping now." → Mom said Sam was sleeping _____.

**a)** then **b)** now **c)** here **d)** later

## Part B · Fill in the Gaps (questions 11–20)

Write the missing word in each blank.

11 "I am tired," Ben said. → Ben said he _____ tired.

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12 "We work hard," they said. → They said they _____ hard.

13 "I will help you," Mia said. → Mia said she _____ help me.

14 "I can't find my keys," he said. → He said he _____ find his keys.

15 "I have seen that movie," Pam said. → Pam said she _____ seen that movie.

16 "I'm studying English," Leo said. → Leo said he _____ studying English.

17 "We visited Rome," they said. → They said they _____ visited Rome.

18 "I don't know the answer," she said. → She said she _____ know the answer.

19 "My brother lives in Spain," Ana said. → Ana said her brother _____ in Spain.

20 "I won't be late," Tom said. → Tom said he _____ be late.

## Part C · Unscramble the Words (questions 21–28)

Put the words in the correct order to make a sentence. Write it on the line. Remember the capital letter and the full stop.

21 **She / said / she / was / tired.**

_____

22 **They / told / us / they / had / seen / the / film.**

_____

23 **He / said / he / would / call / me / later.**

_____

24 **Anna / said / she / couldn't / find / her / keys.**

_____

25 **My / dad / told / me / he / had / lost / his / wallet.**

_____

26 **The / boys / said / they / were / playing / soccer.**

_____

27 **Liz / said / she / was / leaving / the / next / day.**

_____

28 **Tom / said / he / didn't / like / the / food.**

_____

## Part D · Choose and Complete (questions 29–35)

Choose the correct option and write it in the blank.

29 *Choose the correct form.*
Carla said she _____ to the gym every day.
Options: **went** / **goes** / **has gone**

30 *Choose the correct form.*
Dan said he _____ the report by Friday.
Options: **would finish** / **will finish** / **finishes**

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**31** *Choose the correct form.*
They said they _____ their homework.
Options: **had finished** / **have finished** / **finish**

**32** *Choose the correct form.*
Ella said she _____ very tired that night.
Options: **is** / **was** / **will be**

**33** *Choose the correct form.*
Mom said I _____ go out after dinner.
Options: **can't** / **couldn't** / **won't**

**34** *Choose the correct form.*
My friend said he _____ for me for an hour.
Options: **has been waiting** / **is waiting** / **had been waiting**

**35** *Choose the correct expression.*
Last week, she said she was leaving _____ to visit her cousin.
Options: **tomorrow** / **the next day** / **yesterday**

## Part E · Matching (questions 36–40)

Match the items. Write the correct letter next to each number.

**36** Match each direct-speech form with its reported form.

1. will _____
2. can _____
3. am / is / are _____
4. has / have + past participle _____
5. don't / doesn't _____

**A.** could
**B.** would
**C.** had + past participle
**D.** didn't
**E.** was / were

**37** Match each time expression with its reported form.

1. now _____
2. today _____
3. tomorrow _____
4. yesterday _____
5. last week _____

**A.** the week before
**B.** the next day
**C.** then
**D.** that day
**E.** the day before

**38** Match each direct statement with the reported sentence.

1. Tom: "I am tired." _____
2. Ana: "I have a dog." _____
3. Sam: "I will call." _____
4. Eva: "I can sing." _____
5. Jo: "We saw it." _____

**A.** Ana said she had a dog.
**B.** Eva said she could sing.
**C.** Jo said they had seen it.
**D.** Tom said he was tired.
**E.** Sam said he would call.

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**39** Match each reported sentence with the original words.

1. He said he would call. _____
2. She said she could swim. _____
3. They said they were hungry. _____
4. Mia said she had been waiting. _____
5. Tim said he didn't know. _____

**A.** I have been waiting.
**B.** I will call.
**C.** I don't know.
**D.** We are hungry.
**E.** I can swim.

**40** Match each verb form with its reported form.

1. is going _____
2. went _____
3. have eaten _____
4. will be _____
5. has been working _____

**A.** would be
**B.** had been working
**C.** had gone
**D.** had eaten
**E.** was going

## Part F · Find the Error (questions 41–50)

Each sentence has one mistake. Underline it and write the correct word.

**41** He said he lives in Chile when he was a child.
Correct word: _____

**42** Last year Tom said he will move to Paris.
Correct word: _____

**43** Last Monday Eva said she was busy now. Correct word: _____

**44** Ben said he has bought the tickets the day before.
Correct word: _____

**45** Her mother said she can't go out that night.
Correct word: _____

**46** Tina said she didn't see the film before that day.
Correct word: _____

**47** Mark said he is watching TV when I called.
Correct word: _____

**48** Sophie said she doesn't have any money when we went shopping that day.
Correct word: _____

**49** Two days ago he said he would arrive tomorrow.
Correct word: _____

**50** She said she has been working since seven when I called.
Correct word: _____

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# Answer Key

Reported speech – tense changes (backshift)

## Part A · Multiple Choice

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **c)** lived | Present simple becomes past simple. |
| 2 | **a)** were watching | Present continuous becomes past continuous. |
| 3 | **d)** had bought | Past simple becomes past perfect. |
| 4 | **b)** would | Will becomes would. |
| 5 | **b)** could | Can becomes could. |
| 6 | **d)** had finished | Present perfect becomes past perfect. |
| 7 | **a)** didn't like | Don't becomes didn't. |
| 8 | **c)** the next day | Tomorrow becomes the next day. |
| 9 | **d)** had been | Present perfect continuous becomes past perfect continuous. |
| 10 | **a)** then | Now becomes then. |

## Part B · Fill in the Gaps

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 11 | **was** | Am/is/are becomes was/were. |
| 12 | **worked** | Present simple becomes past simple. |
| 13 | **would** | Will becomes would. |
| 14 | **couldn't** (or: could not) | Can't becomes couldn't. |
| 15 | **had** | Present perfect becomes past perfect. |
| 16 | **was** | Present continuous becomes past continuous. |
| 17 | **had** | Past simple becomes past perfect. |
| 18 | **didn't** (or: did not) | Don't becomes didn't. |
| 19 | **lived** | Lives becomes lived. |
| 20 | **wouldn't** (or: would not) | Won't becomes wouldn't. |

## Part C · Unscramble the Words

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 21 | **She said she was tired.** | Am/is/are becomes was/were. |
| 22 | **They told us they had seen the film.** | Past simple becomes past perfect. |
| 23 | **He said he would call me later.** | Will becomes would. |
| 24 | **Anna said she couldn't find her keys.** | Can't becomes couldn't. |
| 25 | **My dad told me he had lost his wallet.** | Past simple becomes past perfect. |
| 26 | **The boys said they were playing soccer.** | Present continuous becomes past continuous. |
| 27 | **Liz said she was leaving the next day.** | Tomorrow becomes the next day. |

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| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **28** | **Tom said he didn't like the food.** | Don't becomes didn't. |

## Part D · Choose and Complete

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **29** | **went** | Present simple becomes past simple. |
| **30** | **would finish** | Will finish becomes would finish. |
| **31** | **had finished** | Present perfect becomes past perfect. |
| **32** | **was** | Is becomes was. |
| **33** | **couldn't** | Can't becomes couldn't. |
| **34** | **had been waiting** | Present perfect continuous becomes past perfect continuous. |
| **35** | **the next day** | Tomorrow becomes the next day. |

## Part E · Matching

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **36** | **1-B 2-A 3-E 4-C 5-D** | will – would; can – could; am / is / are – was / were; has / have + past participle – had + past participle; don't / doesn't – didn't<br>These are the main backshift changes. |
| **37** | **1-C 2-D 3-B 4-E 5-A** | now – then; today – that day; tomorrow – the next day; yesterday – the day before; last week – the week before<br>Time words change in reported speech. |
| **38** | **1-D 2-A 3-E 4-B 5-C** | Tom: "I am tired." – Tom said he was tired.; Ana: "I have a dog." – Ana said she had a dog.; Sam: "I will call." – Sam said he would call.; Eva: "I can sing." – Eva said she could sing.; Jo: "We saw it." – Jo said they had seen it.<br>Shift each tense one step back. |
| **39** | **1-B 2-E 3-D 4-A 5-C** | He said he would call. – I will call.; She said she could swim. – I can swim.; They said they were hungry. – We are hungry.; Mia said she had been waiting. – I have been waiting.; Tim said he didn't know. – I don't know.<br>Undo the backshift. |
| **40** | **1-E 2-C 3-D 4-A 5-B** | is going – was going; went – had gone; have eaten – had eaten; will be – would be; has been working – had been working<br>Each tense moves one step back. |

## Part F · Find the Error

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **41** | **lived** | Backshift: lives becomes lived. |
| **42** | **would** | Will becomes would in reported speech. |
| **43** | **then** (or: at that time, at that moment) | Now becomes then. |
| **44** | **had bought** (or: had) | Present perfect becomes past perfect. |
| **45** | **couldn't** (or: could not) | Can't becomes couldn't. |
| **46** | **hadn't seen** (or: had not seen) | Past simple becomes past perfect. |
| **47** | **was watching** (or: was) | Present continuous becomes past continuous. |
| **48** | **didn't have** (or: did not have) | Doesn't becomes didn't. |
| **49** | **the next day** (or: the following day) | Tomorrow becomes the next day. |
| **50** | **had been working** (or: had been) | Present perfect continuous becomes past perfect continuous. |

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